

The Impact of Social Media on Saudi Children's Food Habits

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Abstract

This study focuses on the impact of social media on Saudi children's food habits and eating behavior. The research was conducted to understand how social media affects children's food choices, interest in fast food, and unhealthy eating habits. Social media platforms expose children to food advertisements, influencers, and digital content that may influence their eating behavior. A questionnaire was distributed to Saudi parents of children aged 8 to 15 years old in order to collect responses related to the research questions. The findings showed that social media has a strong influence on children's interest in trying new foods and increasing their preference for fast food. The results also revealed that influencers and food-related content affect children's food choices and eating habits. In addition, the study found that parents play an important role in reducing the negative effects of social media by guiding children to choose healthy foods and limiting social media use. This study recommends increasing parental awareness about healthy eating habits and monitoring children's exposure to food-related social media content. Future studies should investigate the long-term effects of social media on children's health and nutrition.

Keywords: Social media, Children, Food habits, Saudi Arabia, Eating behavior.

Introduction

In recent years, social media has become an essential part of Saudi children's daily lives. With its quick spread influence, it can easily shape various areas in their life, including diet. The impact of social media on Saudi children's food habits is undeniable, as it can lead them to bad food choices and misleading information. That's why it is crucial for parents to act and guide their children toward healthier diets. Most Saudi children spend a lot of time on social media, and they can get affected by the content they watch, whether it is advertisements or food challenge videos. Guo (2023) conducted a systematic review and meta-analysis examining the impact of unhealthy food marketing on children through social media. The study found that exposure to unhealthy food marketing increases children's preference for unhealthy foods and influences their eating behavior. According to Alanazi (2022), fast-food choices and eating behavior were significantly associated with average daily social media usage. Smith (2018) also found that digital food advertising, including influencer promotions and targeted advertisements, has a strong impact on children's preference for high-fat and high-sugar foods. These marketing strategies are designed to attract children's attention and influence their food choices. Many children in Saudi Arabia spend a lot of time on social media and are exposed to unhealthy food advertisements, which can lead to unhealthy eating habits. Social media should be used to promote healthy eating habits and help children make better food choices. Therefore, parents should monitor their children's use of social media and guide them to choose healthy foods, as well as educate them about healthy eating habits.

The research questions are:

- 1- What are the effects of social media on Saudi children's food habits?
- 2- Why do children rely on social media for their food habits?
- 3- How can parents eliminate the negative effects of social media on their kids?

Methodology

Population and Sample

The population of the study consists of Saudi school children aged 8–15 years old who regularly use social media platforms. These participants include both females and males and are considered a vulnerable group influenced by online content, particularly food advertisements. The sample of the study consists of 50 Saudi children aged 8–15 years old who regularly use social media.

Research Design

This study aims to study the impact of social media on Saudi children's food habits. To do this, the researcher used a questionnaire with three parts based on the three research questions. The first part is about the effects of social media on Saudi children's eating habits. The second part is about why children rely on social media for food choices, and the third part is about how parents can reduce the negative effects. The questionnaire includes 12 items in total and one open question. It was checked and tested before being shared using Google Forms. The questionnaire used a three-point Likert scale (Agree, I don't know, Disagree). After collecting the answers, the data were analyzed and shown using charts to make the results easier to understand.

Results

The results of the questionnaire are organized into three main research questions (RQ1, RQ2, and RQ3). Each research question includes several items that explore different aspects of the impact of social media on children's eating habits. The responses were collected and converted from pie charts into bar charts to make them clearer and easier to compare. Each chart presents the percentages of respondents' answers using the three-point Likert scale (Agree, I don't know, Disagree).

Bar chart 1 shows the respondents answers related to RQ1(What are the effects of social media on children’s eating habits?)

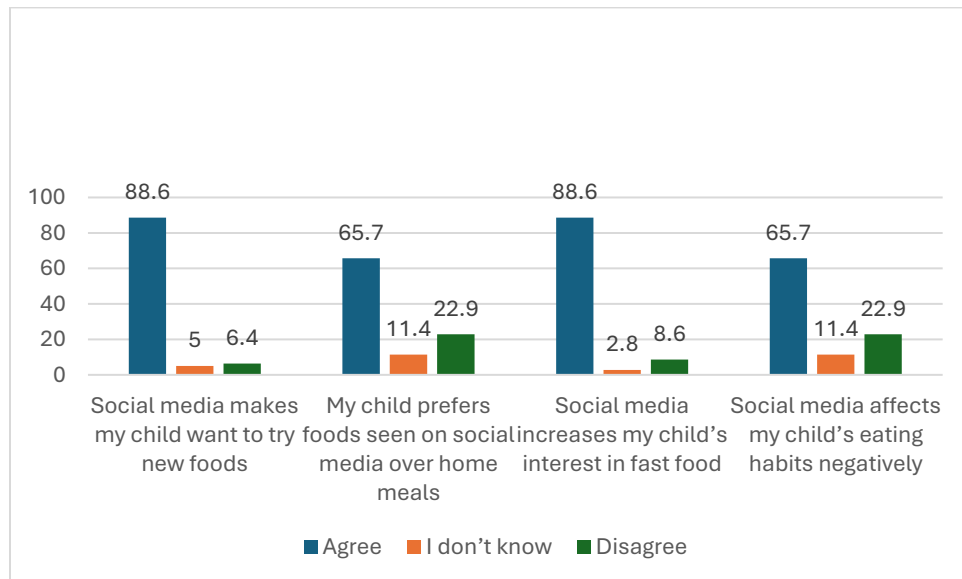


Chart 1 shows the answers for RQ1 regarding the effects of social media on children’s eating habits. The majority of respondents agreed with most statements. For instance, 88.6% of respondents agreed that social media makes their child want to try new foods, and the same percentage agreed that it increases their child’s interest in fast food. In addition, 65.7% agreed that their child prefers foods seen on social media and that social media negatively affects their eating habits. On the other hand, smaller percentages selected “I don’t know” and “Disagree” across all statements. Overall, the results indicate that social media has a strong influence on children’s eating habits.

Bar chart 2 shows the respondents answers related to RQ2(Why do children rely on social media for their food habits?)

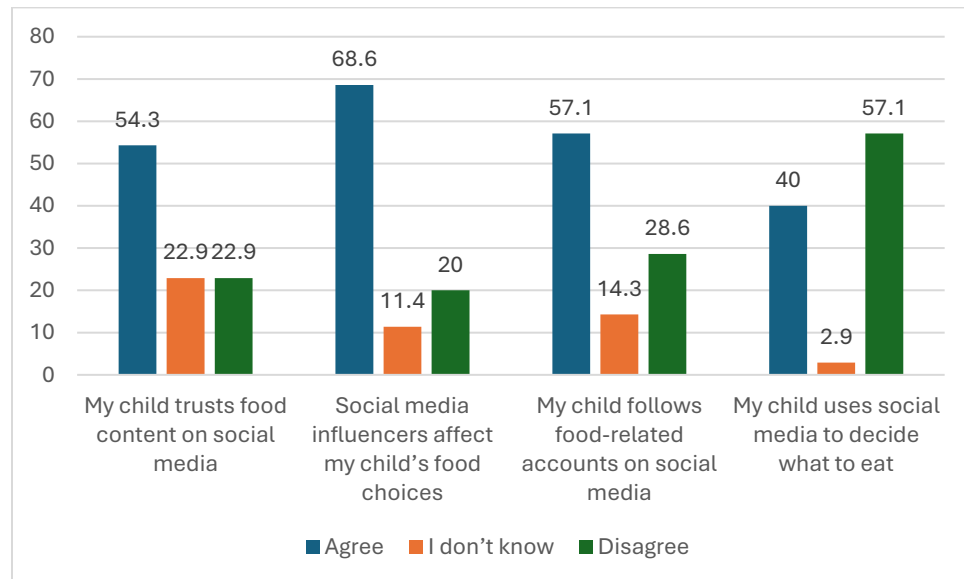


Chart 2 shows the answers for RQ2 regarding why children rely on social media for their food habits. Most respondents agreed with the statements. For example, 68.6% agreed that influencers affect food choices, and 57.1% agreed that children follow food-related accounts. In addition, 54.3% agreed that children trust food content on social media. However, only 40% agreed that children use social media to decide what to eat, while 57.1% disagreed. Overall, the results show that social media influences children's eating habits.

Bar chart 3 shows the respondents answers related to RQ3 (How can parents eliminate the negative effects of social media on their kids?)

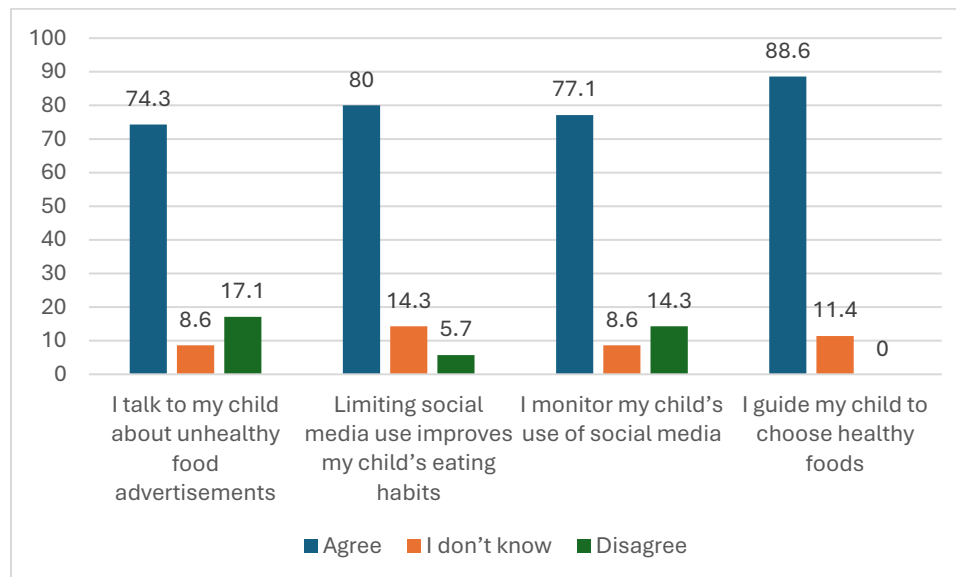


Chart 3 shows the answers for RQ3 regarding how parents can reduce the negative effects of social media on children's eating habits. The majority of respondents agree with most statements. For example, 88.6% agreed that they guide their child to choose healthy foods, and 80% agreed that limiting social media improves eating habits. In addition, 77.1% agreed that they monitor their child's use of social media, while 74.3% talk to their child about unhealthy food advertisements. On the other hand, smaller percentages selected "I don't know" and "Disagree." Overall, the results indicate that parents play an important role in reducing the negative effects of social media.

In conclusion, the results show that social media has a strong impact on children's eating habits. Most respondents agreed that it influences food choices, while parents play an important role in reducing these effects. Overall, parental guidance and control are important in improving children's eating habits.

Discussion

This research mainly focuses on the impact of social media on Saudi children's food habits and how social media affects children's eating behavior and food choices. After developing a questionnaire and collecting responses from Saudi parents, the results were analyzed

according to the three research questions. The major findings showed that social media has a strong influence on Saudi children's food habits and eating behavior. The results also revealed that influencers and food advertisements affect children's food choices, while parents play an important role in reducing the negative effects of social media.

Discussion of RQ1:

Regarding the item "social media makes children want to try new foods," most respondents agreed with this statement, making it one of the highest results in RQ1. Respondents also agreed that social media increases children's interest in fast food. This shows that food advertisements and influencers affect children's eating habits. On the other hand, the item "my child prefers foods seen on social media over home meals" had the lowest agreement among the statements. This may mean that some children still prefer home food. These findings agree with Guo (2023), who found that social media marketing increases children's interest in unhealthy foods. These findings also agree with Smith (2018). This may indicate that social media plays an important role in shaping children's eating behavior and increasing their interest in unhealthy foods.

Discussion of RQ2:

Regarding the item "social media influencers affect children's food choices," most respondents agreed with this statement, making it one of the highest results in RQ2. This refers to the strong influence of influencers and food creators on children's eating behavior. Many children trust influencers and become interested in foods promoted online. In contrast, the item "my child uses social media to decide what to eat" had the lowest agreement among the statements. This may indicate that although children are affected by food content online, they do not completely depend on social media when choosing their meals. These findings are supported by Smith (2018), who explained that influencer promotions and digital food advertisements affect children's food preferences and eating habits. This finding suggests that influencers and online food content affect children's food preferences, even if children do not completely depend on social media when choosing meals.

Discussion of RQ3:

Regarding the item “I guide my child to choose healthy foods,” most respondents agreed with this statement, making it one of the highest results in RQ3. Respondents also agreed that limiting social media use improves children’s eating habits. This refers to the important role of parents in helping children choose healthy foods and reduce the negative effects of social media. These findings agree with Alanazi (2023), who found a strong relationship between social media use and unhealthy dietary habits and explained the importance of parental guidance in reducing unhealthy eating behaviors among children. This implies that parental guidance and monitoring can help reduce the negative effects of social media on children’s eating habits.

Open Question:

Some parents mentioned that children are highly influenced by social media food advertisements, especially through influencers and short videos.

Unexpected Results:

One unexpected result was that many respondents agreed that social media affects children’s eating habits, but fewer respondents agreed that children completely rely on social media to decide what to eat.

Conclusion

This study examined the impact of social media on Saudi children’s food habits and eating behavior. The findings showed that social media affects children’s interest in fast food and unhealthy eating habits. Many children are influenced by influencers and fast-food advertisements shared online. The study also found that parents play an important role in helping children choose healthy foods and reduce the negative effects of social media. One important implication of this study is that parents should monitor children’s social media use and discuss healthy food and eating habits with them. One limitation of this study is that the sample size was small and only included Saudi parents. In addition, the study depended on questionnaire responses, which may not fully represent all children’s eating behaviors. Therefore, future studies should include larger samples from different regions in Saudi Arabia and use different research methods to provide more accurate results. The study also recommends increasing parental awareness about healthy eating habits and reducing children’s exposure to unhealthy food advertisements on social media.

References

Guo, M. (2023). *The impact of unhealthy food marketing on children on social media platforms. Frontiers of Society, Science and Technology*, Vol. 5 No. 15, pp. 58–62. Francis Academic Press.

Smith, R., Kelly, B., Yeatman, H., & Boyland, E. (2018). *Digital food marketing to children and adolescents: A systematic review. International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health*, Vol. 15 No. 5, Article 963.

Alanazi, A. M. L., et al. (2023). *Impact of social media on fast food consumption and increased bad nutritional habits: A systematic review. Saudi Journal of Medical and Pharmaceutical Sciences*, Vol. 9 No. 12, pp. 839–844. Saudi Center for Science and Education.

Appendices

Appendix A:

The questionnaire used in this research.

Dear parents

This questionnaire aims to investigate the impact of social media on Saudi children's food habits.

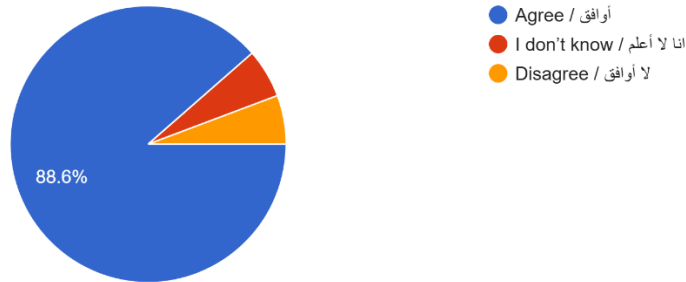
Your participation in this questionnaire is highly appreciated. Please answer the following statements honestly by choosing the option that best reflects your opinion.

1. What are the effects of social media on Saudi children's food habits?	• Social media makes my child want to try new foods.
	• Social media increases my child's interest in fast food.
	• My child prefers foods seen on social media over home meals.
	• Social media affects my child's eating habits negatively.
2. Why do children rely on social media for their food habits?	• My child trusts food content on social media.
	• Social media influencers affect my child's food choices.
	• My child follows food-related accounts on social media.
	• My child uses social media to decide what to eat.
3. How can parents eliminate the negative effects of social media on their kids?	• I monitor my child's use of social media.
	• I guide my child to choose healthy foods.
	• I talk to my child about unhealthy food advertisements.
	• Limiting social media use improves my child's eating habits.

Appendix B

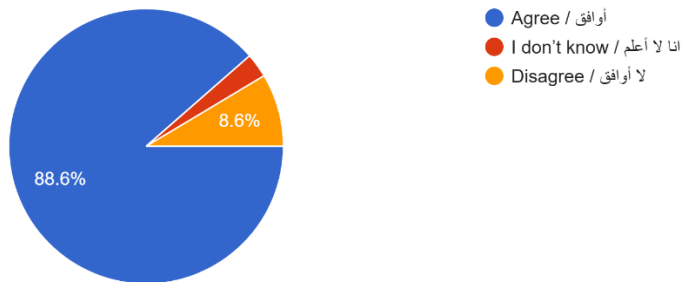
RQ.1 What are the effects of social media on children's eating habits? Social media makes my child want to try new foods. تجعل وسائل التواصل الاجتماعي طفلي يرغب في تجربة أطعمة جديدة.

35 responses



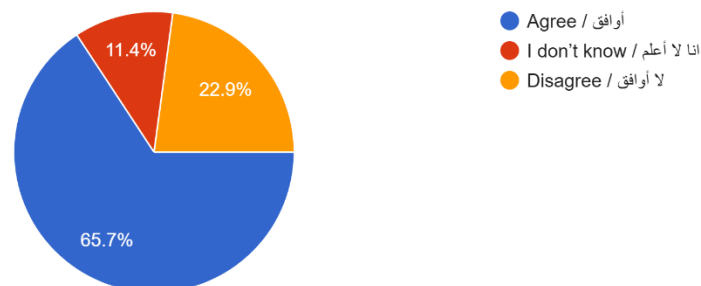
RQ.1 What are the effects of social media on children's eating habits? Social media increases my child's interest in fast food. تزيد وسائل التواصل الاجتماعي من اهتمام طفلي بالوجبات السريعة.

35 responses



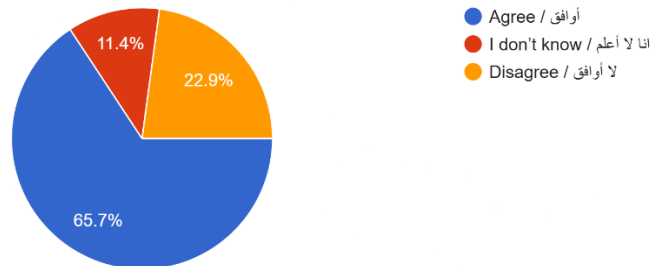
RQ.1 What are the effects of social media on children's eating habits? My child prefers foods seen on social media over home meals. يفضل طفلي الأطعمة التي يراها في وسائل التواصل الاجتماعي على الوجبات المنزلية.

35 responses



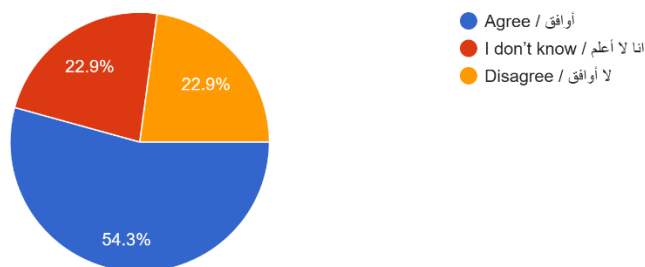
RQ.1 What are the effects of social media on children's eating habits? Social media affects my child's eating habits negatively. تؤثر وسائل التواصل الاجتماعي سلباً على عادات الأكل لدى طفلي.

35 responses



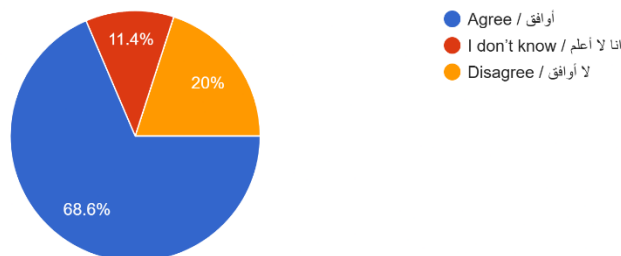
RQ.2 Why do children rely on social media for their food habits? My child trusts food content on social media. يثق طفلي بالمحتوى الغذائي في وسائل التواصل الاجتماعي.

35 responses



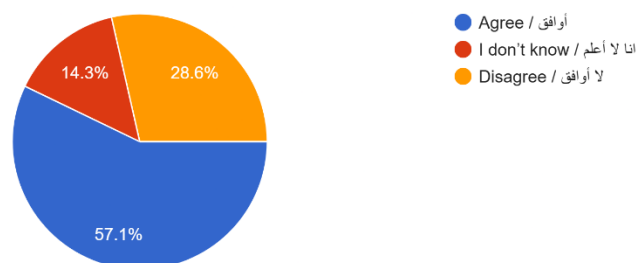
RQ.2 Why do children rely on social media for their food habits? Social media influencers affect my child's food choices. يؤثر مؤثرو وسائل التواصل الاجتماعي على اختيارات طفلي الغذائية.

35 responses



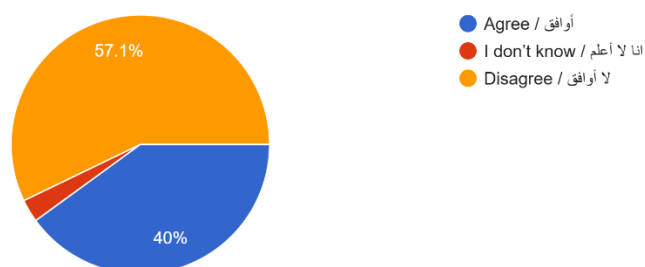
RQ.2 Why do children rely on social media for their food habits? My child follows food-related accounts on social media. يتابع طفلي حسابات متعلقة بالطعام على وسائل التواصل الاجتماعي.

35 responses



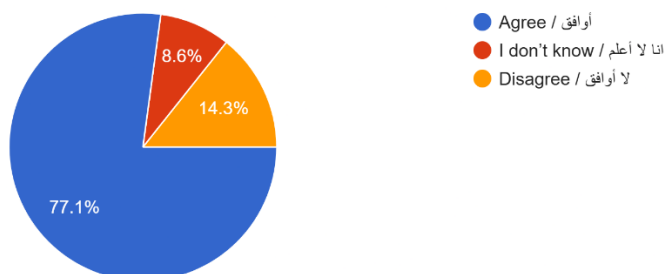
RQ.2 Why do children rely on social media for their food habits? My child uses social media to decide what to eat. يستخدم طفلي وسائل التواصل الاجتماعي لتحديد ماذا يأكل.

35 responses



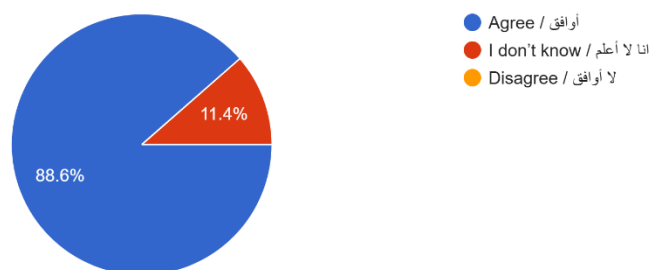
RQ.3 How can parents eliminate the negative effects of social media on their kids? I monitor my child's use of social media. أراقب استخدام طفلي لوسائل التواصل الاجتماعي.

35 responses



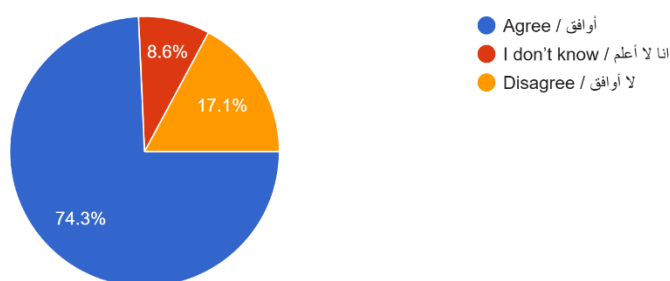
RQ.3 How can parents eliminate the negative effects of social media on their kids? I guide my child to choose healthy foods. أوجه طفلي لاختيار الأطعمة الصحية.

35 responses



RQ.3 How can parents eliminate the negative effects of social media on their kids? I talk to my child about unhealthy food advertisements. أتحدث مع طفلي عن إعلانات الأطعمة غير الصحية.

35 responses



RQ.3 How can parents eliminate the negative effects of social media on their kids? Limiting social media use improves my child's eating habits. تقليل استخدام وسائل التواصل الاجتماعي يحسن عادات الأكل لدى طفلي.

35 responses

